

Engineering Ethics

“What is Ethics And Ethical Behaviour?”

Hochschule Darmstadt University of Applied Sciences

April 24, 2023

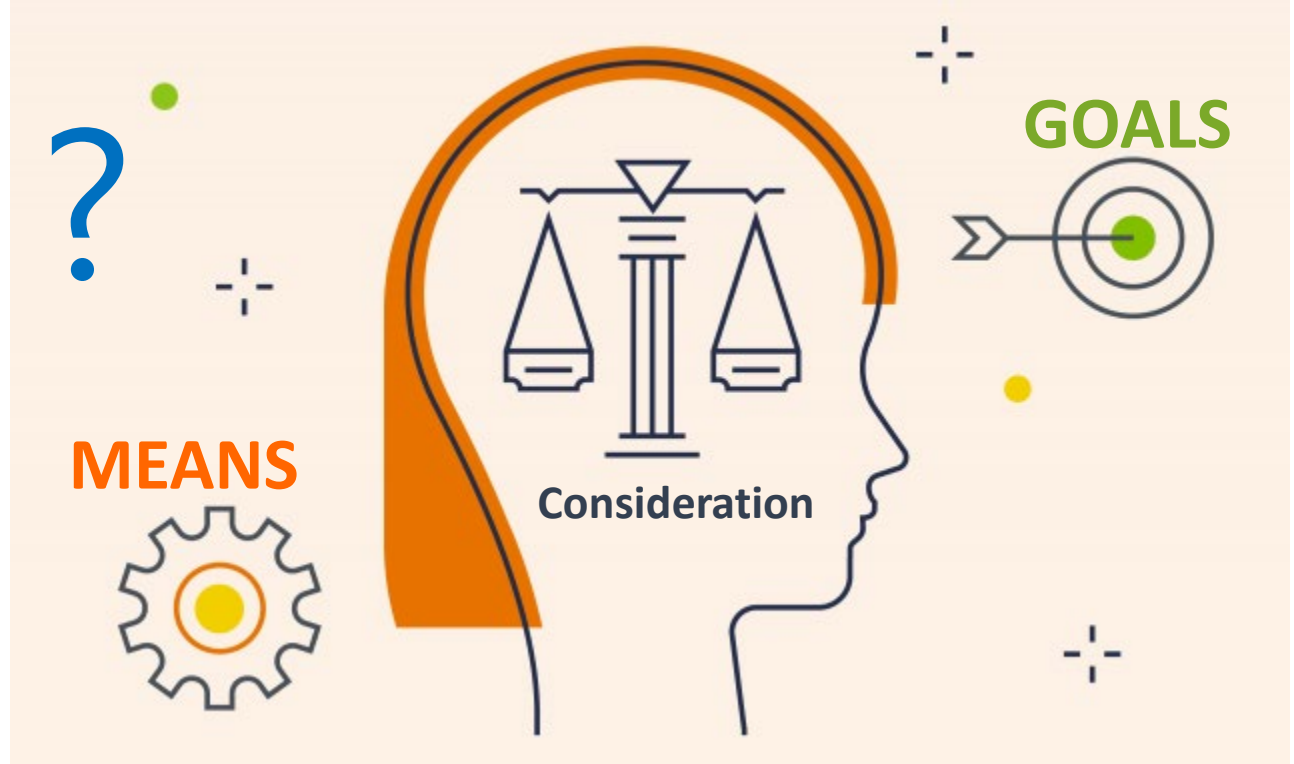
Agenda for today

- Introduction
- What is Ethics?
- The difference between Action and Behaviour?
- Sustainability as a New (additional) Challenge

1

What means the term

„ethics“

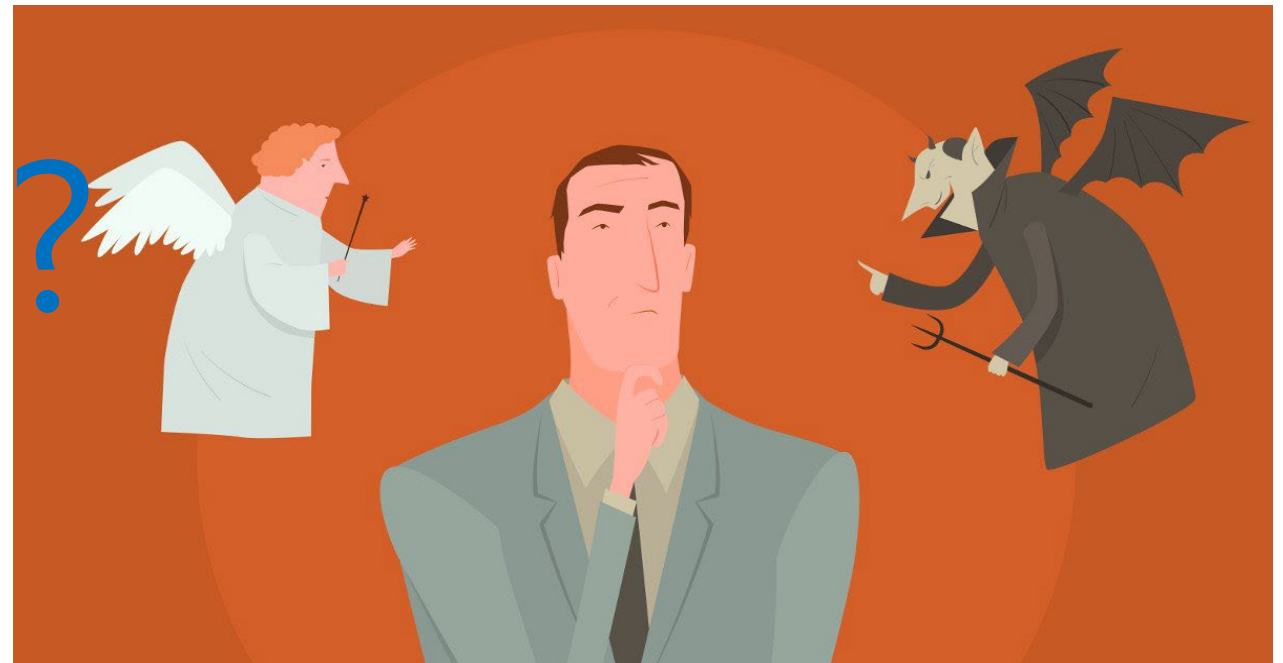


Original taken from: <https://www.thebridgeclinic.com/blog/enforcement-of-ethics-and-standards-amongst-practitioners-of-art-in-nigeria> (modified)

What are decisions you
make that touch

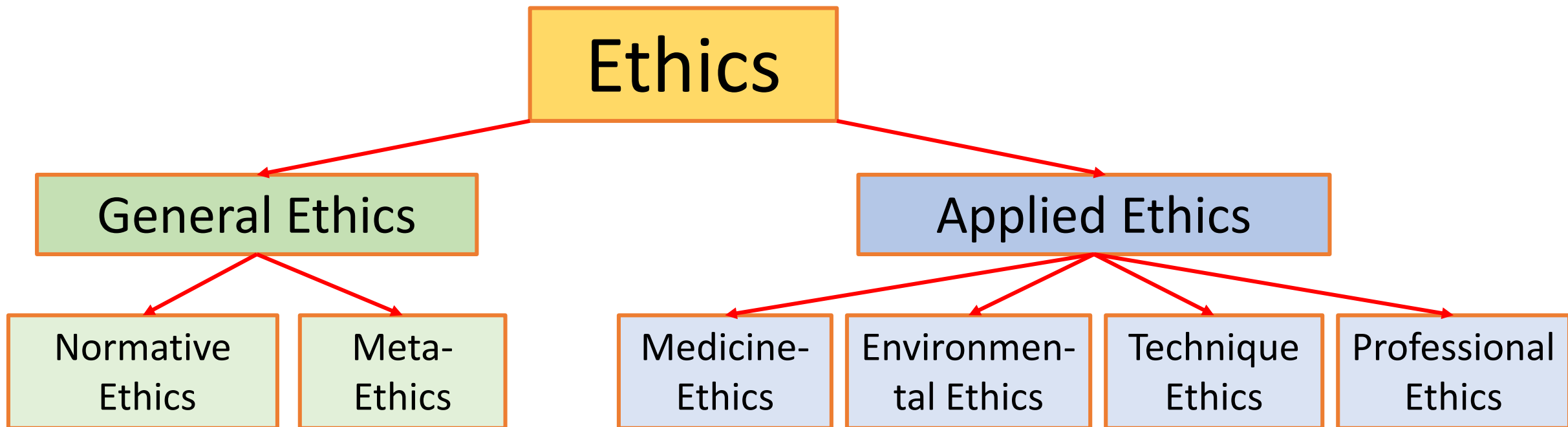
„ethics“

Go to: www.menti.com
and use code: 1446
6363



<https://www.thegreatcoursesdaily.com/ethics-know-right-wrong/> 4

What is Ethics?



Normative Ethic

Individual Ethics

Ethical Pursuit of Happiness

Philosophy of happiness
Individual Conduct of Life



Self-reference

Happiness / a Good Life

Prudential perspective / capability

Social Ethics

Ethics of Ought to Be

Moral Philosophy
Interpersonal coexistence



Interaction

Morality / Fairness

Moral perspective

Normative Ethic

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Happiness / a Good Life

Prudential perspective / capability

An illustrative example:

Peter is married since 12 years and the father of 4 young kids. He wants to leave his family to move into the flat of a young colleague he is in love with. He talks to two of his friends. Both advise him against it.

What would be lines of argument?

Social Ethics

Ethics of Ought to Be

Moral Philosophy
Interpersonal coexistence



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Normative Ethic

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Will the new relationship last long? The separation from your family and children will make you unhappy.

An illustrative example:

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Interpersonal coexistence



Your wife and children depend on you, you must not think only of yourself and leave them in the lurch.

The Categorical Imperative – I. Kant

- The universal principle
 - A person should act according to guiding principle that could become a universal law of human action in a world in which one would hope to live in.
 - A person should treat other people as having intrinsic value, and not merely as a means to achieve individual ends.



Immanuel Kant
1724 – 1804

Groundwork of the Meta-
physics of Morals
(first: 1785)

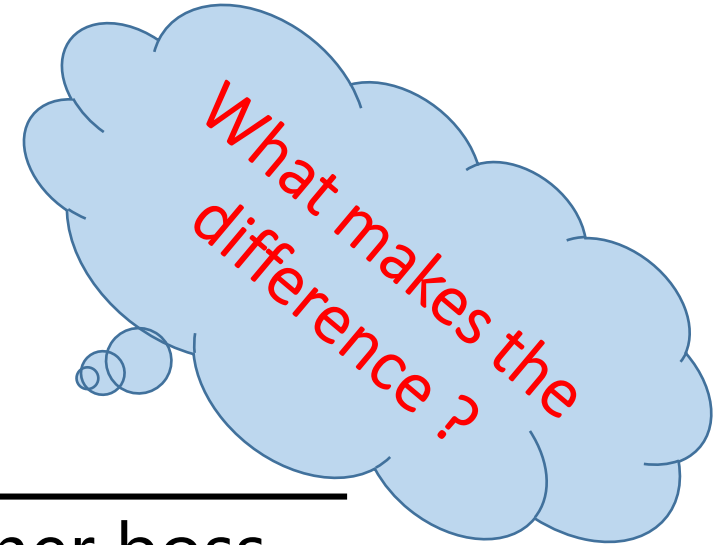
2

The Difference between Action and Behaviour



Action? or Behaviour?

1. Anne writes a letter to her mother.
 2. Frederick plays piano.
 3. Lionel smokes one cigarette after the other.
-
4. Pamela slaps her uninvolved kid in anger at her boss.
 5. Thomas stumbles and breaks his leg.



Examples taken from:
D. Fenner (2008): Ethik. Wie soll ich handeln?
UTB basics, p. 33

Action? or Behaviour?

- Intention is the main difference:
 - The person in focus **wants** to act in a certain way.
 - It is „planned“
 - When acting, the individual activities take place consciously
- But: there is no **clear** Yes or No - it is a continuum.



Action? or Behaviour?

Behaviour is the generic term that covers the totality of all bodily movements and physical expressions of living organisms.

What happened?

Too many
people at the
party?

A provoking arts
performance ?

“I want to do
something nasty!”

A cat on
the table?



Action? or Behaviour?

1. Thomas stumbles and breaks his leg. (behaviour – accident)
 2. Pamela slaps her uninvolved kid in anger at her boss.
(affective act)
-
3. Lionel smokes one cigarette after the other. (routine with usually uncontrolled repetition)
 4. Frederick plays piano. (Acquired skill: movements are not fully controlled but your choice of song)
 5. Anne writes a letter to her mother. (The letter and every sentence is intentional)

Action? or Behaviour?

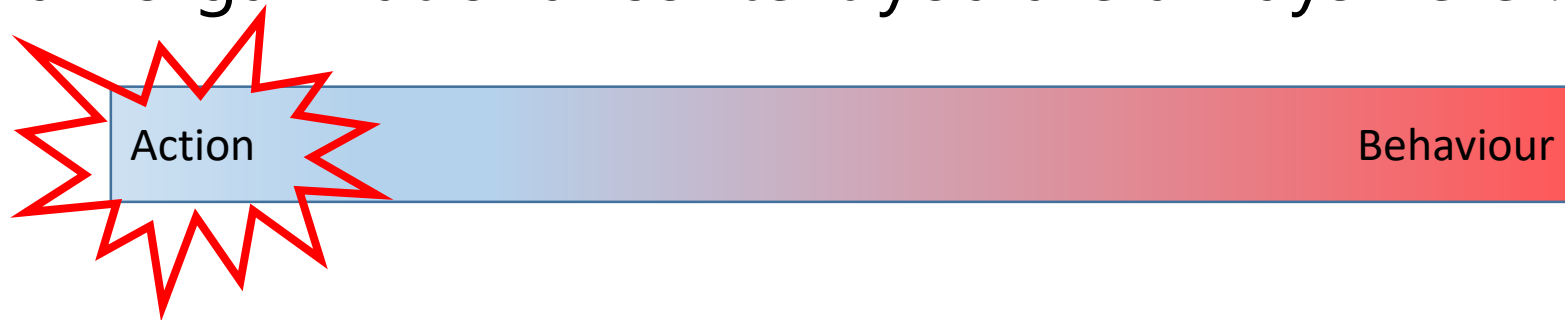
Anne writes a letter to her mother. (The letter and every sentence is intentional)

Why is this an important Question in the context of

"Engineering Ethics"?

Action? or Behaviour?

- **Intention** is the main difference:
 - The person in focus **wants** to act in a certain way.
 - It is „planned“
 - When acting, the individual activities take place consciously
- In an organizational context you are always here !

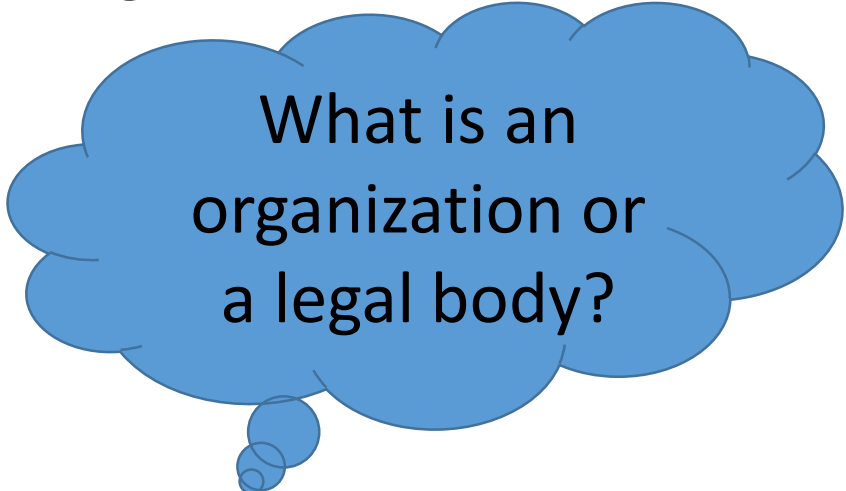


There is no chance for an

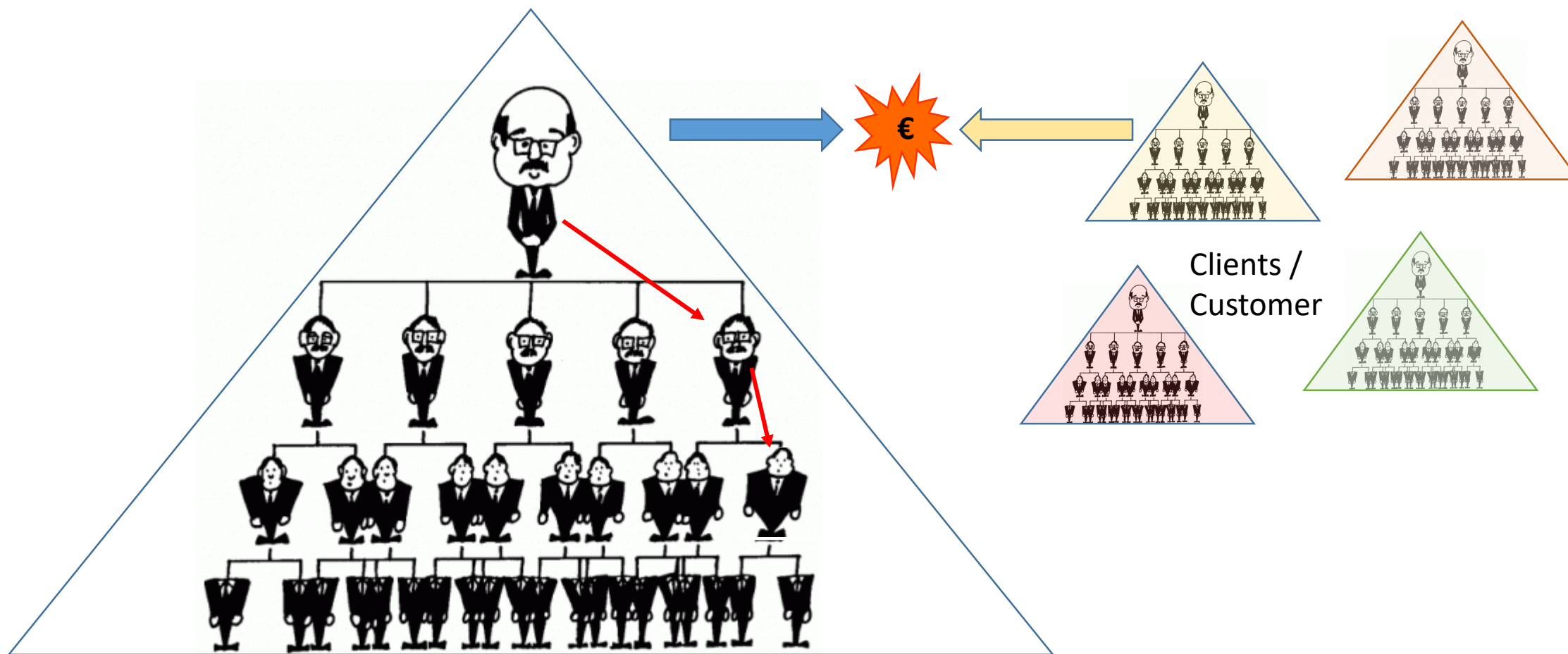


Legal Body/Person vs. Natural Person

- There is no oooops for legal bodies!!!
- Organizations don't act affectively
- The premise is: they are operating decision-based and in a rational manner



What is an
organization or
a legal body?



Sustainability as a new challenge

3



Think for a moment about the past 220 years - so this goes back to the year 1800 ...

What were (the) three outstanding achievements for you?

Sustainability as a new challenge



What do you think:
Why did I raise the topic of
“sustainability” (better:
sustainable development)
in this first lecture?

Sustainability as a new challenge



Talk to another student about
it

What were (the)
three outstanding
achievements for
you?

Sustainability as a new challenge



Brainstorming

Sustainability as a new challenge

What must not be forgotten The development of the last 225 years also includes:

- The democratization of society
 - The free constitutional state
 - Labor protection rights(equal?)
 - educational opportunities
 - Health care
 - Social security
- What we know as liberal democracies.



This enumeration might appear euro-centric – I agree

A twofold question of justice

- **Intra-generational justice:**
Within-generational justice: Equal living conditions for all people living in the world at the moment at one point in time.
- **Inter-generational justice:**
Justice between generations: Development that meets the needs of the current generation without limiting the options of future generations.



